December 2015, offering an attractive ₹79,000-crore loan for a period of fifty years with a moratorium of fifteen years, at an interest rate of 0.1 per cent. The project was on with a body called the National High Speed Rail Corporation Limited (NHSRCL) in place by January 2016 and Prime Minister Abe back in India to lay the foundation stone for the project, along with Prime Minister Narendra Modi, in September 2017.

By September 2018, much of the preparatory work was on full swing. There was a training centre, and a bridge span longer than the one on the Japanese network (220 m) coming up over Vadodara station. [155] But as the project gathers momentum, voices have begun to be raised over land acquisition issues by farmers, land owners and villagers. There have been protests, petitions in courts and appeals to the Japanese to put the project on hold.

Rumours Bring in a Sense of Déjà Vu

There is a sense of déjà vu here. Naysayers and members of the Opposition have fuelled rumours along the stretches of villages, somewhat similar to the time when the first trains were introduced. Here are a few of the objections stated. [156]

- With the bullet train whizzing past over our farms, there will be radiation and vibrations of all kinds and it will affect agriculture and farms, turning the land barren.
- People who are stakeholders for the bullet train are looking for land, and for it to come up, entire villages will be relocated to interior districts of Maharashtra, like Satara or Sangli.
- Due to side filling of tracks of bullet trains, the fertile land will be converted into wetlands.
- This is just a ploy to displace all the tribal population around Palghar district of Thane to make way for future projects like the Mumbai-Delhi industrial corridor.
- After a few years of laying tracks, the stakeholders will come again to acquire more land.

A few villagers even came up with absurd demands saying they now intended to plan start-ups, but now, with land being utilized for the bullet